Free guide

Study smarter with AI

25 copy-paste prompts that help you learn, not just get answers.

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Start here

AI is a tutor, not a ghostwriter

Used well, AI explains things patiently, quizzes you at 11pm and never gets tired. Used badly, it does your thinking for you and you learn nothing. These prompts are built for the first kind of use. Follow three rules and they work much better.

1 Try first, then ask

Spend 5 minutes on the problem yourself. You remember far more when AI helps with the gap than when it does the whole thing.

2 Give it context

Always say your level, your subject or exam, and your goal. "Explain recursion" gets a generic answer. "Explain recursion to an IB Computer Science student" gets a useful one.

3 Check what it tells you

AI can be confidently wrong. Compare against your textbook, class notes or teacher, especially for facts, dates and exam rules.

How to use the prompts

Copy a prompt, replace every **[square bracket]** with your own details, paste it into ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or any AI assistant, and keep the conversation going. Ask follow-ups. Say "explain that more simply" as often as you need.

Never share

- Passwords, full names, addresses or school login details
- Anything private about other people

A Understand it

Get a topic to make sense before you memorise it.

1. Explain [topic] to me as if I'm [age or level]. Then give me one real-life example and one common mistake people make.
2. I'm studying [subject] for [exam or course]. Explain [topic] in 5 short points, then ask me 3 questions to check I understood.
3. Give me 3 different analogies for [concept]. For each one, tell me where the analogy stops working.
4. Here are my notes: [paste notes]. Rewrite them as clear bullet points, and tell me what might be missing for [exam or course].
5. Explain the difference between [A] and [B] in a table. Then give me one example where people mix them up.

B Test yourself

Recalling from memory is what makes revision stick.

6. Quiz me on [topic], one question at a time. Wait for my answer, mark it, and explain. Start easy and get harder.
7. Turn these notes into 15 flashcards, with the question on the front and the answer on the back: [paste notes].
8. Write 5 exam-style questions on [topic] for [level], with mark schemes. Do not show the answers until I reply.
9. Ask me to explain [topic] in my own words. Then point out what I got wrong or left out.
10. Give me 10 true or false questions on [topic] with tricky wording. Explain every answer after I reply.

C Plan it

Turn a big exam into small, doable days.

11 My exam is on [date]. I can study [hours] per week. My topics are: [list]. Build a weekly revision timetable with review days.

12 Rank these topics by how hard students usually find them and how many marks they tend to carry: [list]. What should I study first?

13 I only have [number] days left. Make a plan covering the 10 most important things to know for [subject].

14 Break this task into small steps I can finish in 25-minute sessions: [coursework, essay or project].

D Fix your mistakes

Mistakes are where the learning is. Use them.

15 Here is my answer and the correct answer. Explain exactly where my thinking went wrong, then give me a similar question to try.

16 Do not give me the answer. Give me a small hint for this question: [question]. If I am still stuck, give me a bigger hint.

17 Mark my answer out of [marks] like an examiner. Tell me what earned marks, what lost marks, and how to improve: [paste answer].

18 What are the 5 most common mistakes students make in [topic]? How do I avoid each one?

E Code and computer science

For anyone learning to program or studying CS.

19 Explain this code line by line in plain English. Do not change it: [paste code].

20 My code has a bug. Do not fix it. Ask me questions that help me find it myself. Code and error: [paste].

21 Give me 3 practice problems on [concept, for example loops in Python], from easy to hard, with no solutions yet.

22 Show me the same solution written two ways: a beginner way and a cleaner way. Explain the differences.

F Learn anything

Use these for a new skill, a course, or a long article.

23 I want to learn [skill] in [time]. I have [hours] per week and I am at [level]. Make a weekly plan with a small project each week.

24 What do I need to already know before learning [topic]? Check my knowledge with 5 quick questions.

25 Summarise this in 10 bullet points, then ask me 5 questions to make sure I really understood it: [paste text].

Use it honestly

Do this, not that

Do

- Attempt the question first, then ask for a hint
- Ask AI to explain why, not just what
- Ask it to quiz you on what you just learned
- Check important facts against your own notes
- Tell your teacher how you use it if they ask

Don't

- Paste in homework and hand in the answer. Schools check, and you lose the learning
- Trust a single answer on anything that matters, such as exam rules or dates
- Study only by reading AI summaries. Test yourself instead
- Share personal or school information

For parents: 5 questions to ask your child

- "Show me the prompt you used." It tells you what they are really doing.
- "Can you explain the answer to me without the screen?"
- "Did you check it against your notes or textbook?"
- "What did you try before you asked the AI?"
- "What did you get wrong, and what did you learn from it?"

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Study packs: shahmikh.com/resources.html

Parent's AI Pack: a calm guide to raising kids in the age of AI, with 30-day family printables.

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